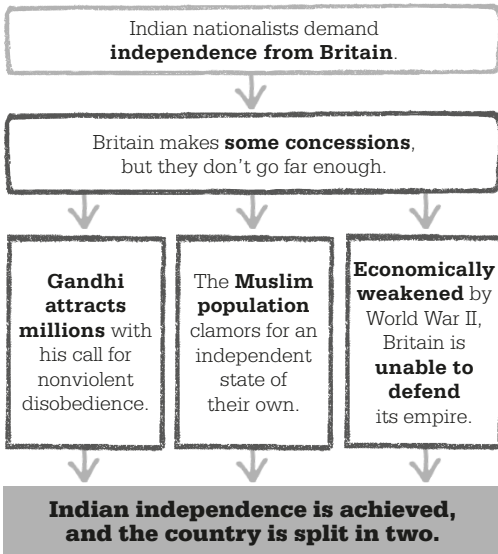


Mohandas Gandhi

The Indian national leader known as Mahatma, meaning "great soul," Mohandas Gandhi (1869–1948) led his country to independence from Great Britain. He came from a Hindu family and studied law in England before spending 20 years in South Africa trying to secure rights for the Indians living there.

Gandhi's involvement in Indian politics began in 1919, and he soon became the unquestioned leader of the independence movement. He preached the doctrine of Satyagraha (soul force, or passive resistance) which he applied against the British with great effect. He adopted a simple life, believing in the virtue of small communities, and campaigned against Indian industrialization.

Gandhi's life work was crowned in 1947, when India finally won independence, but the concessions he had made to the Muslims led to his assassination the following year by a Hindu fanatic, who blamed him for the partition of India, although Gandhi himself bitterly opposed the dismemberment of the subcontinent.

the Government of India Act (1919), which created an Indian parliament where power was shared between Indians and British officials. This did not satisfy Indian nationalists, and the British responded to their protests with sometimes brutal repression.

The push for independence from the 1920s to the 1940s was galvanized by the work of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi. Gandhi not only launched the Satyagraha campaign, promoting nonviolent protest, but also became an influential figure for millions of followers. In 1942 Gandhi led the "Quit India" campaign, calling for civil disobedience to disrupt Britain's efforts in World War II. The British immediately jailed Gandhi and other nationalist leaders.

By the end of World War II, it was clear that Britain lacked the means to defeat the nationalist campaign. Britain's officials in India were utterly exhausted, and Britain itself was almost bankrupt. Britain agreed to a fully independent India. While Gandhi and Nehru advocated Indian unity, the Muslim League, founded in 1906 to safeguard the rights of Muslims, demanded a completely separate Muslim state. Its leader, Mohammed Ali Jinnah, feared that Muslims could not protect their minority rights if left to live under Hindu rule. Congress rejected the proposal and violence on the streets between Hindus and Muslims began to escalate. »